

Complex Subordinate Clauses

C1 · Renan the Teacher — English Language Academy

1. BRIEF EXPLANATION

Subordinate clauses let you link a main idea to a secondary one with precision. At C1 you need to control three families beyond simple "because" / "although":

- a) Concessive clauses (contrast) — even though, although, though, whereas, while, in spite of / despite (+ noun or -ing).
 - - "Even though / although / though" + clause show a surprising contrast: Even though it was raining, we went for a walk.
 - - "Whereas / while" contrast two facts neutrally, often side by side: She loves cities, whereas he prefers the countryside.
 - - "In spite of / despite" + noun/gerund (never a full clause directly): Despite the rain, we went for a walk. / Despite working hard, she failed.
- b) Purpose clauses — so as to, in order to/that, for the purpose of.
 - - "So as to" / "in order to" + bare infinitive express purpose formally: We left early so as to avoid the traffic.
 - - "In order that" / "so that" + clause (with can/could/will/would) are used when the subject changes: I gave her my number so that she could contact me.
- c) Result clauses — such...that, so...that.
 - - "So" + adjective/adverb + "that": The exam was so difficult that half the class failed.
 - - "Such" + (a/an) + adjective + noun + "that": It was such a difficult exam that half the class failed.

Register note: "in order that," "so as to," and "whereas" belong to formal/written English; "so," "although," and "but" are fine in speech.

2. EXAMPLES

- 1. Even though she was exhausted, she finished the marathon.
- 2. Whereas the north of the country is mountainous, the south is flat.
- 3. Despite having no experience, he got the job.
- 4. In spite of the criticism, the director refused to change the ending.
- 5. We arrived early so as to get good seats.
- 6. She whispered so that no one else would hear.
- 7. He studied hard in order to pass the bar exam.
- 8. The music was so loud that we couldn't hear each other talk.
- 9. It was such a compelling argument that the jury changed its mind.
- 10. While I understand your concerns, I still disagree with the decision.
- 11. The report was so poorly written that it had to be redone.
- 12. He left the company in order that his rival could take over.

3. COMMON MISTAKES

- 1. Incorrect: Despite he was tired, he kept working.

Correct: Despite being tired, he kept working. / Although he was tired, he kept working.

Why: "Despite/in spite of" take a noun or gerund, not a subject + verb clause.

- 2. Incorrect: The film was such interesting that I watched it twice.

Correct: The film was so interesting that I watched it twice.

Why: "So" goes with an adjective alone; "such" needs a noun (such an interesting film).

- 3. Incorrect: She works hard so as she can support her family.

Correct: She works hard so that she can support her family. / She works hard in order to support her family.

Why: "So as to" takes an infinitive, not a clause; use "so that" for a full clause with a modal.

- 4. Incorrect: Whereas he is generous, but she is quite mean.

Correct: Whereas he is generous, she is quite mean.

Why: Don't combine "whereas" with "but" — the contrast is already built into "whereas."

- 5. Incorrect: It was so a boring lecture that half the room fell asleep.

Correct: It was such a boring lecture that half the room fell asleep.

Why: With "adjective + noun," use "such (a/an)," not "so."

4. EXERCISES

- A. Gap-fill (so, such, whereas, despite, in order to/that, so as to)
- 1. ___ the traffic, we arrived right on time.
- 2. He whispered the plan ___ no one would overhear.
- 3. It was ___ a long meeting that people started checking their phones.
- 4. The coffee here is excellent, ___ the tea is rather weak.
- 5. She left the party early ___ catch the last train.
- 6. The instructions were ___ confusing that nobody followed them correctly.
- 7. He trained every day ___ improve his stamina.
- 8. ___ having a fever, she still went to work.
- 9. He spoke slowly and clearly ___ everyone in the room could understand.
- 10. It was ___ a generous offer that we couldn't refuse it.
- B. Rewrite / Transformation
- 1. He is rich, but he lives very simply. (rewrite with "whereas")
- 2. She failed the exam, but she didn't lose confidence. (rewrite with "even though")
- 3. He turned down the promotion. He wanted more free time. (join with "in order to")

- 4. It rained heavily. We still finished the hike. (join with "despite")
- 5. The test was extremely hard. Nobody finished it in time. (join with "so...that")
- 6. He apologized publicly. He wanted to repair his reputation. (join with "so that")
- 7. It was a very persuasive speech. It changed several votes. (join with "such...that")
- C. Error Correction
- 1. Despite he arrived late, no one seemed to mind.
- 2. It was so an emotional film that everyone cried.
- 3. She practiced every day so as she could improve faster.
- 4. Whereas I respect his opinion, but I think he's wrong.
- 5. The meeting was such long that we had to order dinner.
- 6. In spite of he lost the match, he stayed positive.
- D. Guided Production
- 1. Write one sentence about your own life using "even though."
- 2. Write one sentence using "whereas" to contrast two people or places you know.
- 3. Write one sentence using "so...that" describing a memorable experience.
- 4. Write one sentence using "in order to" about a goal you're working toward.

5. ANSWER KEY

- A. Gap-fill
- 1. Despite/In spite of
- 2. so that
- 3. such
- 4. whereas
- 5. so as to / in order to
- 6. so
- 7. so as to / in order to
- 8. Despite/In spite of
- 9. so that
- 10. such
- B. Rewrite / Transformation
- 1. He is rich, whereas he lives very simply.
- 2. Even though she failed the exam, she didn't lose confidence.
- 3. He turned down the promotion in order to have more free time.
- 4. Despite the heavy rain, we still finished the hike.
- 5. The test was so hard that nobody finished it in time.
- 6. He apologized publicly so that he could repair his reputation.
- 7. It was such a persuasive speech that it changed several votes.
- C. Error Correction
- 1. Despite arriving late / Although he arrived late, no one seemed to mind.
- 2. It was such an emotional film that everyone cried.
- 3. She practiced every day so as to improve faster / so that she could improve faster.
- 4. Whereas I respect his opinion, I think he's wrong. (remove "but")
- 5. The meeting was so long that we had to order dinner.
- 6. In spite of losing the match / Although he lost the match, he stayed positive.
- D. Guided Production (sample answers)

- 1. Even though I was scared of heights, I went skydiving for my birthday.
- 2. My sister loves spontaneous trips, whereas I prefer planning every detail in advance.
- 3. The concert was so loud that my ears were ringing for hours afterward.
- 4. I've been saving money in order to travel around South America next year.

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